

During the 1930s, the world shifted from a period of aspiration toward disarmament into widespread rearmament. By the second half of the decade, an arms race was under way, with the militarist governments of Germany and Japan and their potential enemies pumping money into military aviation. Advances in aircraft design, engines, and general aviation technology already seen in commercial and racing airplanes were applied to a new generation of military aircraft, while wars in China and Spain gave some air forces the chance to try out their new airplanes and tactics for real.

The Luftwaffe returns

After Adolf Hitler's rise to power in 1933, Nazi Germany began what would soon become a general rearmament in Europe. Like his fellow dictator Mussolini, Hitler found in aircraft an image of dynamism, modernity, and power that reflected his own vision of the Nazi state, as well as a practical tool for achieving his military ambitions. He ordered an immediate and massive program of expansion in military aviation that was already well under way by the time the recreation of the Luftwaffe was publicly announced in 1935.

“Germany is once more a world power in the air. Her air force and her air industry have emerged from the kindergarten stage. Full manhood will still not be reached for three years.”

MAJOR TRUMAN SMITH

US MILITARY ATTACHE IN BERLIN, 1936

The official head of Nazi German aviation was Hermann Göring, but the true mastermind behind the rapid resurgence of the Luftwaffe was former Luft Hansa director Erhard Milch. Despite all that had been done to keep the “shadow Luftwaffe” in existence, Milch faced a daunting task in creating the large air force Hitler demanded. Between 1933 and 1936, he expanded Germany's aircraft production by a staggering 800 percent, as well as training an entire new generation of pilots.

Although Milch's achievement was impressive – especially when new designs such as the



“OUR LUFTWAFFE”

Secretly reformed in 1923 in defiance of the terms of the Treaty of Versailles, the Luftwaffe's resurgence after the Nazis came to power in Germany in 1933 was masterminded by Erhard Milch. In 1935 its existence was publicly announced with posters such as this (left), promoting “Our Luftwaffe” in German.

Messerschmitt Bf 109 fighter and the Junkers Ju 87 Stuka dive bomber began to roll

off the production lines in the second half of the decade – the Luftwaffe was never quite as strong as its potential enemies thought it to be. Nazi propagandists ensured that the image of German air power was stamped on the imagination of foreign peoples and their leaders, undermining the will to resist Hitler's ever-escalating demands. But after 1936, the pressure to create a numerically massive air force, for which sufficient resources were not really available, led to chaotic inefficiency and disorganization – characteristics in any case typical of all parts of the Nazi system.

Former World War I ace and stunt flier Ernst Udet, appointed as Luftwaffe technical director and later head of aircraft production, became a wild card within the system. Among the many decisions by Udet that caused consternation, the most famous is probably his demand that the impressively fast Ju 88 medium bomber, ready to enter production in 1938, should be modified so it could also act as a dive bomber. The result was a redesign that cut the bomber's speed from 310mph (500kph) to 185mph (300kph) and delayed its introduction by two years. With Udet and Milch at loggerheads and Göring pursuing his own erratic and self-serving course, it is a tribute to the abilities of German designers, scientists, and fliers that the Luftwaffe still proved such an impressive force.

PROPAGANDA PLANE

A Tupolev ANT-20 “Maksim Gorkii” flies over a 1935 May Day parade in Moscow's Red Square. The propaganda plane was fitted with loudspeakers, a printing press, and a pharmacy.

Allied developments

From 1935 onward, Britain and France were acutely aware of the threat posed by the resurgence of the Luftwaffe. It coincided with the realization that their existing air fleets were rapidly becoming obsolescent because of technological developments. The RAF's new fighter ordered into production in 1935 was the Gloster Gladiator biplane (which won fame during the defense of Malta in 1940–41), but fortunately a prototype of the Hawker Hurricane flew in the same year and the Supermarine Spitfire was taking shape on the drawing board. More sensible, if less dynamic, than the Nazis, the liberal democracies embarked on a longer term but relatively slow development of new models and the industrial setup to manufacture them. By 1938, state-of-the-art monoplanes were reaching RAF squadrons in growing numbers and production accelerated rapidly as an uneasy peace turned to war. Unfortunately for the French, their progress was slower and new models, such as the

